ChannelRecipe

FREE HARNESS · 3D DOCUMENTARIES

The 3D Documentary Harness

The two rules behind the 3D reconstruction channels blowing up right now: lock the look with Visual DNA, and open every story with Rule 13.

Rule 1 · Visual DNA
Camera, light, mannequins, pacing and call-outs, taken from 3+ reference videos

Rule 13 · The hook
Coordinates, one human in one seat, the sudden failure

Rule 13 · The script
Ten beats from the cold open to the last line

START HERE

How to use this harness

Paste the harness into your AI's project instructions (a Claude Project, a `CLAUDE.md` or a custom GPT). Then give it your reference videos and your topic.

1. **Pick 3 or more reference videos** from one channel or one niche. Use their best performers, not their latest uploads.
2. **Run Rule 1** on every one of them and fill in the Visual DNA block (page 5).
3. **Write your script with Rule 13:** the hook first, then the ten beats.
4. **Hand over both together:** give your 3D tool or editor the DNA block and the script, and check every shot against the DNA before you render.

RULE 1

The Visual DNA rule

A trait belongs to the Visual DNA only if it appears in every reference video.

In all of them	In some	In one
It's DNA. Never break it.	It's allowed: use it when the story needs it.	Ignore it. That was a one-off, not the style.

Score the references on five traits, in this order: **camera**, **lighting**, **mannequins**, **shot pacing** and **3D text call-outs**. Each trait has a starter value. Replace it with what you measure.

> **Tip:** watch each reference at half speed with a stopwatch, and screenshot a frame every 2 seconds. Lay the screenshots side by side, and what stays the same jumps out.

1 Camera: focal length and the slow isometric dolly

MEASURE	HOW TO MEASURE IT	STARTER VALUE
Focal length	Do straight lines bend at the edges? Do near objects balloon? Match it to 24, 35, 50 or 85 mm (full-frame equivalent).	35 mm wides, 50 mm mid shots and inserts, never fisheye
Camera angle	How far the camera looks down on the scene	Isometric feel: 30 to 35° down, the camera 1.5 to 2× the subject's height
Dolly speed	Time how long the frame takes to travel one frame-width	2 to 3% of the frame width per second (a full cross takes about 40 s)
Move style	Constant speed, or eased? Does it ever stop?	Constant glide with a 0.5 s ease in and out; never cut mid-acceleration

2 Lighting: single-point volumetric light in a dark room

MEASURE	HOW TO MEASURE IT	STARTER VALUE
Light sources	Count the shadows each object casts	One key light (a spot or practical lamp), 45° above and to the side
Volume	Can you see the beam in the air?	A visible beam: haze or fog at 10 to 20%
Darkness	How dark the background gets, from 0 (black) to 255 (white)	The background falls close to black (under about 25 of 255); no fill light
Separation	How subjects separate from the dark	A faint rim light on silhouettes

3 Mannequins: consistent red and blue shaders

MEASURE	HOW TO MEASURE IT	STARTER VALUE
Faces	Are the people detailed or faceless?	Faceless mannequins, no hair, no texture
Colour code	Which side gets which colour, every time	Red = the people in danger Blue = everyone else. Never swapped.
Material	Glossy, matte or plastic?	One matte shader per colour, the same hex values all video long

4 Shot pacing

MEASURE	HOW TO MEASURE IT	STARTER VALUE
Hook shots	Median shot length in the first 30 s	1.8 to 2.5 s
Body shots	Median shot length after the hook	3.5 to 5 s
Longest hold	The longest single shot	About 8 s, saved for the money shot
Breathing beats	What happens before each new section	1 to 1.5 s with no narration, music only

5 3D text call-outs

MEASURE	HOW TO MEASURE IT	STARTER VALUE
Position	Where labels sit in the frame	Anchored to the object with a thin leader line, in the upper third, never over the action
Size	Text height as a share of the frame height	About 3.5% of the frame height, uppercase sans-serif
Timing	How long each stays on screen	At least 2 s; one call-out per shot
Entrance	How it appears	A quick fade-and-scale (about 6 frames), no bounce

> **The constant-rule test, in one line:** if you can't find a trait in all three references, it isn't DNA, however good it looks.

RULE 1 · THE OUTPUT

Your Visual DNA block

Fill this in from your references and paste it above every script. It's the contract every shot has to keep.

```
visual_dna:
  references: [video 1, video 2, video 3]
  camera:
    focal_length_mm: { wide: 35, mid: 50 }
    angle: isometric, 30-35 deg down
    dolly_speed: 2-3% of frame width per second, constant, 0.5 s ease
  lighting:
    key: single point, 45 deg high and to the side
    volume: visible beam, haze 10-20%
    background: near black, no fill, faint rim
  mannequins:
    faces: none
    red: "#C8372D"   # the people in danger
    blue: "#2F6FD6"  # everyone else
    material: matte, one shader per colour, never changes
  pacing:
    hook_median_s: 2.0
    body_median_s: 4.0
    longest_hold_s: 8
    breathing_beat_s: 1.2
  callouts:
    anchor: object, thin leader line
    zone: upper third, never over the action
    size: 3.5% of frame height, uppercase sans-serif
    min_on_screen_s: 2
    per_shot: 1
  allowed_not_dna: []   # traits seen in only some references
```

> **Check every shot before it renders.** If a shot breaks a DNA rule, fix the shot, not the rule.

RULE 13

The investigative hook

Open on three ingredients, in this order, within the first 15 to 20 seconds.

01

Exact coordinates and the vessel's stats

The precise time, the altitude, depth or location, then what it is: its type, its size, how many aboard. Real numbers, spoken exactly.

02

One specific human in a specific seat

A name, a role, exactly where they sit. The viewer rides the rest of the video in that seat.

03

The sudden mechanical failure

The moment the machine stops behaving: the part, the sound, the warning light. Don't explain it yet.

The fill-in formula

Exact time and date . Altitude, depth or location above or below place .
Vessel type , size or key stat , number people on board.
In seat or station , full name , role , one human detail .
Then the part fails, in one verb .

EXAMPLE · B-59, OCTOBER 1962

October 27th, 1962. One Soviet submarine. Eleven American warships. And one nuclear torpedo. B-59 is trapped off Cuba. Batteries dying. Air thick with carbon dioxide.

Coordinates, vessel stats and a failing machine in under 15 seconds. The human in the seat, Vasily Arkhipov, is held back for the decision point.

Hook rules

- Every number is exact and sourced: altitude, time, headcount.
- No "in this video we will...". The failure is the promise.
- Present tense. It is happening now.
- Each sentence gets its own shot, and every shot keeps the DNA.

Where, who, what broke

The hook is only the first beat. The whole script runs on the same three ingredients. These beats fit an 8 to 12 minute video.

#	BEAT	TIME	WHAT IT DOES
1	**Cold open**	0:00 – 0:20	The three Rule 13 ingredients, on fast hook cuts.
2	**Stakes and promise**	0:20 – 0:45	One hard number (the odds, the toll, what was at risk) and what we will reconstruct, minute by minute.
3	**The machine**	0:45 – 2:00	A 3D cutaway of the vessel: the three facts that made it *should-have-been-safe*. A breathing beat before the next section.
4	**The people**	2:00 – 3:00	Two to four specific humans: name, seat or station, one trait each. Red or blue by side, all video long.
5	**The timeline**	3:00 – 7:00	Minute by minute with the clock on screen: normal, then the first anomaly, then the failure, then each decision. Present tense.
6	**The decision point**	7:00 – 8:00	One person, one choice, in the seat from the hook. Slow down and hold the money shot.
7	**The outcome**	8:00 – 9:00	What happened, shown plainly.
8	**The investigation**	9:00 – 10:30	What the recorders, reports or survivors revealed, and what everyone got wrong at the time.
9	**What changed**	10:30 – 11:30	The rule, design or procedure that exists because of this.
10	**The last line**	final 15 s	Back to the human in the seat: a quote, a final number, or the one thing they did.

Script rules

- **One sentence, one shot.** Every sentence can be a single 3D scene.
- **Never invent dialogue.** Quote the record, or say nobody knows.
- **Every call-out names something real:** a part, a place, a time, a person.
- **Numbers spoken exactly**, and every one sourced.
- **A breathing beat** of 1 to 1.5 s before each new section.
- **The last line goes back to the seat** from the hook.

THE NICHE LIST

Channels blowing up this week

Study the breakouts, not the averages. Add the channels you find and run Rule 1 on their top three videos.

CHANNEL	WHAT THEY MAKE	BREAKOUT VIDEO	VIEWS
Reconstructed @Reconstructednews	3D cockpit and incident reconstructions	What Really Happened Inside the flydubai Cockpit	3.2M
Neurox-EK @Neurox-EK	Minute-by-minute flight reconstructions	What Really Happened Inside the Four 9/11 Flights	169K
Scary Interesting	Investigative disaster stories	The Most Dangerous Mountain You've Never Heard Of	911K

ChannelRecipe

Skip the days of setup. Get cooking.

Doing all of this by hand takes days. ChannelRecipe does it for you, on your own computer.

1

Clone a channel's style

Paste your reference videos. Studio measures their cuts, motion, colour, music and sound effects, watches them, and learns the look as a recipe you can reuse. That's Rule 1, done for you.

2

Use the 3D Reconstruction recipe

Paste a Rule 13 script and press Create video. Studio directs, reviews and renders the 3D scenes.

3

Make it yours

Pick your narrator, your palette and your 3D look: a clean white studio or colour film.

Start cooking today

Your first 3D documentary, from title to render.

channelrecipe.com